A New World

A Monologue

by Gabriella Diaz

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When I paid for my mother to come to this country, it was the happiest day of my life. My mother, she was not happy. She was leaving the only thing she'd ever known, her beautiful homeland, her friends and, to her, even her memories. She was not happy, but she was proud. Proud that we were doing it, bettering ourselves. And to my mother, being proud of your life was more important than being happy while you live it.

Opportunity knocked in the U.S. I could hear it all the way across the ocean. Knock knock knock knock knock. My husband would find a job, our children would go to school, and college. Each of these thoughts knocked on my brain, drove me to find a way.

And the doctors here, in the U.S. they would help my mom. With her arthritis. Her constant cough. Her bladder infections. Such great doctors in America, and they would help my mother, help her be comfortable, the way she deserved. Well then, as soon as we got here, we took her to a couple doctors. Generalists and specialists. She charmed them, both the one who spoke Spanish and laughed at her jokes, and the one who spoke English and admired her strength. She would curse the Spanish doctor when they examined her aching joints, and then say, "The devil is in my blood, so I have to let him out by cursing because I am too old to dance!"

The third doctor we took her to, was to talk about some of her memory problems. She had been having trouble remembering things, like my daughter's name. Back home, no one worries about this. It's normal. Here, though, the doctor was concerned, he ran tests.

A month after my mother arrived in this country, we were told she had Alzheimer's. That meant a lot of things. But to me, it meant only one thing: the life I had finally made for her, she would have almost no time to enjoy it.

It was ok for two years. We saved money fast, my husband, my brother and I, and bought a house and started renting rooms to tenants. My mother had her own little apartment. None of the tenants spoke Spanish, but they liked her, they would smile and try to chat while she swept the front porch or sat looking at the yard and road. Sometimes, she seemed a little confused, or lost, but no worse than any of us if we're tired. One couple had a baby while they stayed with us, and my grandmother cooed over it like it was her own grandchild. Whenever I watched it, I would smile, but I would also here another thought knocking on my brain, knock knock knock knock knock, eager to come in, something I did not want to think quite yet.

I had another child, Marco. Lola and Marco. My grandmother loved Marco, although sometimes she would call him Jorge, my brother's name. She would ask him if he was going to work in the city for the sugar companies. She meant back home. That wasn't so bad, because you could laugh about it. But what was bad were those times you would show her the baby, and she wouldn't understand at all. Her eyes went blank, like a cloudy sky at night, no stars, no twinkle of recognition.

I had gotten us all over here, so I could figure this out, right? I had a whole plan, here is how we could teach her to remember the kid's names, or find them quickly. I go in one morning to start, and I say hello, and she looks at me and says, "who are you?" And then every day, every hour, she would forget

something new. My husband, her son, that we had moved to the U.S., that she was not a young woman.
A week later I found her at the front door, with her bags packed. She was looking at the road, hopefully. "Where are you going, mama?"

She said, "I'm waiting for Luis."

"Luis?"

"Yes, from the vocational school. We are going on a date."

Luis, her high school sweetheart. She was waiting for him to come and take her out. She had forgotten my father, too. That she was ever married. "Marriage? I think maybe, if Luis likes me enough and my mother likes him..." That was her response when I asked about dad.

I would still let her outside to sweep the front walk. She insisted. And then people started showing up at my front door. My new friend Nancy, from two blocks away. She found my mother wandering down the sidewalk. The father of two teenagers next door, who came to complain that my mother had been screaming at his children in Spanish for fifteen minutes about how scandalously they were dressed. And then, two construction workers. They had come back to their van for lunch to find my mother inside, with a bag, asking them when they were leaving for the town next door - next door to where she grew up. It seemed if Luis was not going to come for her, she would go to him.

We went through three nurses, each of whom my mother cast off like junkyard dogs. She spat on one, and stole another's phone, calling random numbers and asking if they knew their friend was a prostitute who poisoned old ladies. All of them quit within a month.

When I finally locked her in her room, the tenants complained. She would knock at her door, from thie inside, day and night, getting louder when they walked by. Very fast and insistent, Knock, knock, knock, knock, knock, knock. I even tried... tying her down at night, but then she started yelling... I had to let her knock. My kids were scared, too. Even if you knew it was only her, you could not shake the feeling that there was a ghost behind that door.

She is suffering so much. She can't take care of herself. She doesn't understand that, though, so she tries, and she just suffers more. And she doesn't know I want to take care of her. Yesterday, I brought her lunch, she asked why I was poisoning her. Did I want her money, or her jewelry? She doesn't have either, anymore. Why do we live past a certain point, when life has nothing left for us? A slow burn of those energies that once fueled everything, now they just need to be used up.

I was thinking about that when I came across my son in the back yard. He had a grasshopper trapped under a glass. "Let him out, or he'll suffocate!" I almost fell over when I said it. It was like opening the door, between the thinking part of your mind, and the feeling part, in the back, that usually stays closed, doing what it wants. And it had been up to something. It had thought the most forbidden thought.

My mother, so helpless, just a tiny grasshopper waiting to be eaten. Waiting to suffocate under the weight of the world. Knocking on that glass, knock knock knock knock.

Sometimes, you have to help nature along. With compassion.

Something is knocking on the other side of her door. Knock, knock, knock, knock. Is it still her? I haven't checked in a while. I don't remember who she was. All I see is a little grasshopper.

There's so much left in this world for me. My children will go to college and succeed in their new country. Opportunity awaits them. I even heard someone say it here, an idiom, for when life offers you something new: Opportunity knocks. Knock, knock, knock, knock.